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The Third Force: How the DPM Could Overtake the NNP

The Democratic People's Movement won 1,189 votes in its first election, 21,378 behind the NNP, and beat it in just one seat. New parties have risen quickly in Grenada before, but only after an older party had fallen apart. This volume maps the DPM's only realistic route to second place.

BY GREG HOSTEN

GRENADA, CARRIACOU AND PETITE MARTINIQUE, GRENADA

ST. GEORGE'S, GRENADA—Peter David launched the Democratic People's Movement at the Grenada Trade Centre on 16th November 2025, before a crowd that spilled out of the hall. He described a movement nurtured on street corners and founded on the conviction that a nation's strength lies in the participation of all rather than the power of a few. Less than a year later, the DPM fought its first general election.

> **"The DPM's path to second place runs through the NNP, not around it."**
> GREG HOSTEN

The result was sobering. The DPM contested nine seats and won 1,189 votes, 1.9 per cent of the total, and Mr. David lost the Town of St. George, which he had first won in 2003. Yet in the Town the DPM achieved what third parties in Grenada seldom manage: it pushed the NNP into third place. This volume asks whether the DPM could replicate that nationally, and become the second major party, by 2030/31.

THE SIZE OF THE GAP

The arithmetic is stark. The NNP won 22,567 votes and the DPM 1,189. To draw level, the DPM would need nineteen times as many votes as it won in 2026, or the NNP would have to lose most of the support it retained even in the worst defeat of its history.

The DPM's vote was, moreover, concentrated in a single place. Of its 1,189 votes, 730, or 61 per cent, came from the Town of St. George, and across its other eight seats it averaged 57 votes. Its best results outside the capital were 87 for Charmaine Gibbs in St. George South and 82 for its deputy leader, Arley Gill, in St. John. It did not stand at all in six constituencies, among them St. David and St. George North East, the second- and third-largest electorates in the country.

A realistic target makes the scale of the challenge plain. If the NDC wins around 35,000 votes in 2030/31 on a similar turnout, the DPM would need roughly 13,500 votes to finish ahead of the NNP, assuming the two opposition parties divide the remainder. That is about eleven times its 2026 total.

WHERE THE DPM IS ALREADY SECOND

In the Town of St. George, the DPM won 730 votes to the NNP's 536. It finished ahead of the NNP in 10 of the 12 polling divisions, including all five at the National Stadium, which together gave it 454 votes; only in the two divisions at the Anglican Senior School did the NNP come second.

This was Mr. David's personal vote, built over twenty years as the Town's representative for two different parties. In 2022 he won the seat for the NNP with 1,329 votes; in 2026 he and the NNP's Troy Noel had 1,266 between them, of which Mr. David took more than half. The seat demonstrates that the DPM can outpoll the NNP where it fields a known and rooted candidate, and also how difficult that achievement is to replicate elsewhere.

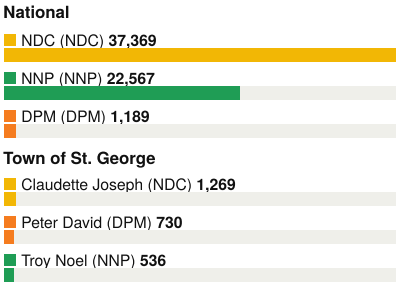
IT HAS HAPPENED BEFORE

Grenada's party system is younger and more fluid than it appears. The NNP itself was formed in August 1984 through a merger of smaller parties, and won the election that December. The NDC was founded on 18th October 1987 by George Brizan and Francis Alexis, in opposition to the NNP government, and within three years it was in office, having won 7 of the 15 seats in 1990 with 34.5 per cent of the vote.

The GULP, Sir Eric Gairy's party, dominated

NATIONAL VS TOWN OF ST. GEORGE

Votes by candidate, in party colours



21,378 votes

Gap between the NNP and the DPM, nationally, in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

1,189

DPM votes in nine seats, 1.9 per cent of the total

730

DPM votes in the Town, ahead of the NNP's 536

10 of 12

Town polling divisions where the DPM beat the NNP

21,378

Votes between the NNP and the DPM nationally

Grenadian politics for a generation; in 2026 it won 34 votes, all of them in St. John and St. George South East. Second place in Grenada is not a permanent possession.

The precedents, however, share a common thread. The NNP and the NDC both rose by bringing together established politicians, sitting or former members with local followings of their own, at a moment when an older party was divided or discredited. Neither grew one voter at a time from a single seat, and if the DPM is to become the second party, it will be by the same route.

FIVE THINGS THE DPM WOULD HAVE TO DO

What follows is the strategy a third party in the DPM's position would require, and each step is measurable.

1. WIN THE TOWN

A party with no seat in parliament has no platform. The opposition's senators are appointed on the advice of the Leader of the Opposition, and with the NNP holding the only opposition seat, the DPM has neither a seat in the House nor one in the Senate. Winning the Town is therefore its first task. In 2026 it would have needed 540 more votes to overtake the NDC; some could come from the 536 who voted NNP, and the remainder would have to come from the 1,687 registered voters in the Town who did not vote.

2. BECOME THE HOME FOR A REALIGNMENT

The DPM cannot overtake the NNP through organic growth alone. Its only realistic route is to attract established figures: former NNP candidates and branch officers who conclude, after a defeat of 14 seats to one, that the old party cannot win again. The NDC was built in that way in 1987. Whether it happens again depends less on the DPM than on how the NNP conducts itself over the next two years.

3. CONTEST EVERY SEAT, WITH CANDIDATES NAMED EARLY

A party that fields candidates in nine seats cannot finish second nationally. The DPM needs candidates in all 15 constituencies, named by 2028 and rooted in the seats they contest. Every earlier volume of this series has documented the cost of late or parachuted candidates, and a new party can afford them even less.

4. SAY WHAT IT IS FOR

In 2026 the DPM's message centred on unity and participation, and on its leader. To become a major party, it needs a programme that voters can distinguish from those of both the NDC and the NNP: on the cost of living, on jobs for young people, and on how government should work. A party built around one person is bounded by that person's constituency; a party built around an idea can travel.

5. BUILD BEYOND THE CAPITAL

The DPM's 459 votes outside the Town are a starting point, not a base. It needs branches and polling-division captains in the seats where it barely registered, beginning with the constituencies where its candidates performed best, and a permanent presence in the six seats where it did not stand at all.

THE ROAD TO SEATS

Finishing second in votes is one ambition; winning seats is another, and under first past the post it is the one that counts. A third party can matter in parliament in two ways: by winning a handful of seats and holding the balance of power, or by winning eight and forming a government. The arithmetic of 2026 shows how distant each prospect is.

A RULE OF THUMB: 40 PER CENT

In a seat where three parties are competitive, a candidate can win with well under half the vote. As a working benchmark, this volume uses 40 per cent of the votes cast in 2026, sufficient to win a three-way contest in most circumstances, though not where one rival remains strong. The table on this page shows how many more votes the DPM would have needed in each constituency to reach that mark.

Only one seat is close. In the Town, 40 per cent was 1,016 votes, the DPM had 730, and it therefore needed 286 more. In every other constituency it needed more than 1,000 additional votes, and in St. David almost 3,000. Across the eight easiest seats on that measure, the total is about 9,300 additional votes, roughly eight times the party's national total in 2026.

A MINORITY: HOLDING THE BALANCE

The more realistic ambition is a small bloc of seats. Grenada has had finely balanced parliaments before: the NDC formed a minority government in 1990 with 7 of the 15 seats, and the NNP governed from 2003 with a majority of one. Should the NDC fall back and the NNP recover, a result such as 7–6 with two seats for a third party would place the DPM in a position to decide who governs.

To get there, the DPM would need the Town plus one or two further seats. The evidence of this series suggests that the seats a small party can win are not the closest two-way marginals, where voters fear wasting their votes, but seats where a well-known local figure carries a personal vote; Vol. 7 showed Delma Thomas taking her vote with her when she changed parties in St. Andrew North West. A DPM minority strategy therefore depends on recruiting two or three people with that kind of following, whether sitting or former members, long-serving councillors or community leaders, and standing them in their home seats.

Holding the balance also requires a decision the DPM should make early and publicly: on what terms would it support a government? A party that states in advance what it would demand, such as campaign finance rules, constituency budgets or a specific policy programme, gives voters a reason to support it even if they do not expect it to govern.

A MAJORITY: THE EIGHT-SEAT MAP

A majority is a task of a different order. It would require the DPM to rise from 1.9 per cent of the vote to something like 40 per cent nationally in a single election, and neither of Grenada's two major parties achieved that on its own: the NNP won in 1984 as a merger of several parties, and the NDC, three years after its founding, won 34.5 per cent in 1990 and formed a minority government.

On the 40 per cent measure, the DPM's eight easiest seats would be the Town, St. Patrick East, St. Mark, St. George North West, St. Patrick West, St. George South East, St. Andrew North West and St. Andrew South West. That the list includes St. George North West, the NNP's last fortress, shows how little room there is. A DPM majority could come only from a full realignment of the opposition, with most of the NNP's organisation and voters moving across, or from a merger; it cannot come from organic growth within one electoral cycle.

The honest conclusion is that the DPM's realistic seat target for 2030/31 lies between one and three seats. A majority is a ten-year project at best, and one that depends on what becomes of the NNP.

THE FOUNDER'S QUESTION

Every party in Grenada must eventually answer the same question: what happens after its founder? The NNP took two years too long to answer it, and paid the price in 2026. For the DPM the question arrives early, because so much of what it won came from one man.

WILL MR. DAVID STAND AGAIN?

Mr. David was born in 1957. By 2030/31 he will be in his mid-seventies, and he has represented the Town in four parliaments since 2003. At the time of writing, he has not said publicly whether he will lead the DPM into another election.

His personal standing is not in doubt. Before the election, polling attributed to Peter Wickham and discussed on a local radio programme gave him a rating of 6.7 against 5.3 for his NDC opponent, yet he still lost by 539 votes. A strong personal rating did not survive a national wave, and that single result encapsulates the DPM's dilemma.

If Mr. David stands again, the DPM retains its only proven vote-winner but risks remaining a one-seat, one-person party. If he does not, it loses the 730 votes that made up most of its total, unless someone else can inherit them. Either way, the decision cannot be deferred until the writ.

A SUCCESSOR, MENTORED IN TIME

The best example of a handover in this series is St. George North West, where Dr. Keith Mitchell named Dr. Adrian Joseph ten months before polling day and campaigned beside him, and the NNP's share fell by only 2.4 points against a national swing of 10.3. Where the NNP left succession to chance, as in St. Mark and St. George South East, it fell much further.

If the DPM is to outlast its founder, Mr. David should name a successor, or a small leadership team, by the end of 2028, leaving two years for the new leader to become known before an election that could come early. The successor should be given substantive work from the outset: a national portfolio such as the cost of living, a target seat to build, and a place beside Mr. David in the Town, walking the Stadium divisions that gave the party 454 votes.

The test of a worthy successor is not loyalty but whether that person can win votes the founder cannot: younger voters, voters outside the capital, and NNP supporters who would never vote for Mr. David after the split of 2024. The party's deputy leader, Arley Gill, is the obvious first candidate, but he won 82 votes in St. John. Whoever is chosen will have to build a base of their own, and the founder's task is to make room for it.

TWO SUCCESSIONS, NOT ONE

Mr. David holds two positions that the DPM will eventually need to fill: the party's candidate in the Town of St. George, and its political leader. They are different jobs, they call for different qualities, and they need not be filled by the same person. Treating them as a single decision is the most common way founder-led parties get succession wrong.

The Town requires someone the capital already knows, who can hold the 730 votes Mr. David won and find the 286 more that would bring the party to 40 per cent. The leadership requires someone who can speak for the DPM in every constituency, raise money, recruit candidates and hold the movement together. A candidate who is excellent at one may be poorly suited to the other.

A SUCCESSOR FOR THE TOWN OF ST. GEORGE

The Town is the one seat the DPM can realistically win, and Mr. David's vote there was personal, built over twenty years. A successor will inherit it only if voters see the handover happen in front of them. The best candidate is someone who lives in the constituency and is already known in it: a councillor, a church or community leader, a small-business owner on the Carenage or a professional raised in the Stadium divisions, rather than a newcomer brought in from elsewhere. Vol. 1 showed what happened to the NNP when it chose a candidate who lived outside the seat.

The method is the one that held St. George North West for the NNP in 2026. Mr. David should name his preferred Town candidate publicly, ideally in 2027, with the branch endorsing the choice. For the next three years the two should walk the twelve polling divisions together, beginning with the five National Stadium divisions that gave the DPM 454 votes and the older town divisions at Marryshow House and the SDA School, where the margins were smallest. The successor should take over constituency casework and community events while Mr. David is still in public life, so that voters come to the new candidate for help before they are asked for a vote.

Success can be measured. By 2029 the candidate should have a household list covering every division, a captain in each of the twelve, and recognition in independent polling close to Mr. David's own. On polling day the target is simple: hold the 730, and reach the 1,016 votes that would have given the DPM 40 per cent of the Town in 2026.

A SUCCESSOR FOR THE PARTY LEADERSHIP

The leadership is a national job and should be filled by a national process. The DPM elected Mr. David as political leader by a unanimous delegate vote at its first congress in March 2026; his successor should be chosen the same way, by delegates at a congress, in an open contest with published rules. The NNP's 2024 convention, held two years late and ending with the losing candidate alleging that it was rigged, is the precedent to avoid. A leadership that delegates have chosen freely is far harder for opponents, or disappointed rivals, to challenge later.

Mr. David can still shape the outcome without dictating it. He can identify two or three potential leaders early, give each of them a visible national role, such as spokesperson on the cost of living, on youth employment or on the diaspora, and let members judge them on their work over two years. The deputy leader, Arley Gill, is the natural starting point, but an open field gives the party a real choice and gives the eventual winner real authority. The congress should be held by the end of 2028, so that the new leader has at least two years before an election that could come early.

Once the vote is held, the most important thing Mr. David can do is accept it in public and campaign for the winner, whoever that is. A founder's endorsement after a fair contest is worth more than any endorsement before one.

ONE PERSON OR TWO?

There is a case for combining the two roles. A party leader outside parliament has no platform in the House, as the NNP discovered when its own leader lost her seat in 2026, and the Town is the DPM's only seat within reach. If the new leader is also a credible candidate in the capital, standing there gives the party its best chance of a parliamentary voice.

The risk is concentration. If the leader stands in the Town and loses, the party loses its seat and its leader's standing in a single night, as the NNP did in St. Andrew South East. The safer arrangement for a small party is often to separate the roles: a rooted local candidate in the Town, and a leader who builds a second target seat, so that the DPM has two routes into parliament rather than one.

Whichever model the DPM chooses, three conditions decide whether it succeeds: both successors are named early enough to become known, both are chosen through processes the party's members accept as fair, and Mr. David visibly hands over rather than holding on. A founder who manages both successions well can leave behind a party. One who leaves them to chance leaves behind a memory.

FROM CANDIDATE TO CHAIRMAN

One option is for Mr. David to step off the ballot and into an executive role, such as party chairman or president, while a new political leader fronts the DPM at elections. Caribbean parties commonly use this arrangement, and the NNP did so: Dr. Mitchell relinquished the leadership in 2024 and remained party chairman until 2026.

The NNP's experience also illustrates the risk. The New Today reported that the new leader still relied on Dr. Mitchell for financial support and to draw supporters to meetings. A party with two centres of power invites the question of who is really in charge, and opponents will pose it loudly.

Should Mr. David take that route, the role ought to be written into the party's constitution and kept narrow, covering fundraising, the diaspora and mentoring rather than candidate selection or the day-to-day message. He should set a public date for the handover, support his successor without qualification, and refrain from second-guessing in public. A founder who watches over a party can protect it; a founder who continues to steer it makes his successor look like a stand-in.

THE MONEY QUESTION

Grenada has no public funding for political parties, no limits on donations or spending, and no requirement for parties to disclose their finances, according to the International IDEA political finance database. Observer missions from the Organization of American States have repeatedly recommended campaign finance rules. In practice, every party depends on private money, and voters do not know who provides it.

It is therefore impossible to judge from outside whether the DPM has the backing to endure. What is clear is the scale of the task: candidates in all 15 seats, offices that stay open between elections and paid organisers for four years cost far more than a single campaign. The NNP's caretakers who were left without offices in 2025 show what happens to a party, even an established one, when the money runs thin.

The DPM took its campaign to Toronto and Brooklyn within weeks of its launch, and the diaspora is a natural base. A party that promises a new type of politics could also turn the absence of rules to its advantage, building a broad base of small donors and members' dues rather than relying on a few large backers, and publishing its accounts voluntarily. That would distinguish it from both major parties. The clearest indicator of whether the money exists will be simple: whether the DPM's offices remain open in 2028.

WHAT COULD STOP IT

The strongest argument against the DPM's rise is that the NNP's 22,567 voters did not leave in 2026. Many NNP supporters stayed at home, but those who voted remained loyal to their party, even in defeat. Everywhere except the Town, the NNP finished first or a clear second, and the DPM a distant third or not at all. Party loyalty in Grenada runs deep.

There is also the risk of being squeezed. Under first past the post, voters who want to remove a government tend to rally behind the strongest challenger, and if the NNP recovers even part of its 2022 vote, the DPM could find itself where the GULP stands today. The DPM's best result, moreover, depended on a single candidate; if Mr. David does not stand again, the Town result may prove unrepeatable.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE NNP

The DPM's path to second place runs through the NNP, not around it. Only if the NNP fails to settle its leadership, loses more of its people and leaves its supporters without a reason to vote can the DPM become the opposition. In that sense this volume is a warning rather than a forecast.

For the NNP, the lesson of the Town is the same as in Vol. 1: together, the two parties were three votes from winning; apart, they finished second and third. Whether 2030/31 brings a reunited opposition, a realigned one or one that remains divided will decide more than which party comes second. It may well decide whether the NDC wins a third term.

VOTES THE DPM WOULD NEED FOR 40 PER CENT, SEAT BY SEAT

Constituency	DPM 2026	40% of 2026 vote	Extra votes needed
Town of St. George	730	1,016	286
St. Patrick East	68	1,136	1,068
St. Mark	—	1,126	1,126
St. George North West	—	1,172	1,172
St. Patrick West	53	1,353	1,300
St. George South East	66	1,484	1,418
St. Andrew North West	39	1,495	1,456
St. Andrew South West	—	1,505	1,505
Carriacou and Petite Martinique	—	1,523	1,523
St. Andrew South East	19	1,552	1,533
St. Andrew North East	45	1,627	1,582
St. John	82	1,845	1,763
St. George North East	—	2,058	2,058
St. George South	87	2,631	2,544
St. David	—	2,982	2,982

40 per cent of valid votes cast in 2026, a rough benchmark for winning a three-way contest. — : the DPM did not stand. The eight easiest seats need about 9,300 extra votes in total. 2026 figures provisional.

THE DPM'S FIRST ELECTION, SEAT BY SEAT

Constituency	Candidate	Votes	Share	Place
Town of St. George	Peter David	730	28.6%	2nd
St. George South	Charmaine Gibbs	87	1.3%	3rd
St. John	Arley Gill	82	1.8%	3rd
St. Patrick East	Dishon Edwards	68	2.4%	3rd
St. George South East	Stanford Simon	66	1.8%	3rd
St. Patrick West	Andy Best	53	1.6%	3rd
St. Andrew North East	Pamela Williams	45	1.1%	3rd
St. Andrew North West	Olvine Holas	39	1.0%	3rd
St. Andrew South East	Shirley McQueen	19	0.5%	3rd
Total, nine seats		1,189	1.9%	

Share of ballots cast in the constituency. The DPM did not contest St. George North West, St. George North East, St. Andrew South West, St. David, St. Mark or Carriacou and Petite Martinique. 2026 figures provisional.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. The DPM trails the NNP by 21,378 votes and needs about eleven times its 2026 total.
2. 61 per cent of the DPM vote came from one seat.
3. In the Town it beat the NNP in 10 of 12 polling divisions.
4. New parties have become major ones in Grenada, but only through realignment.
5. Without a seat, the DPM has no platform in parliament: the Town comes first.
6. A party in nine seats cannot finish second: it needs all 15.
7. First past the post squeezes third parties when voters want change.
8. Realistic seat target for 2030/31: one to three, enough to hold the balance.
9. A majority needs a realignment or merger, not one cycle of growth.
10. Name a Town candidate in 2027 and walk the twelve divisions together.
11. Choose the next leader at an open congress by the end of 2028.
12. If he moves to an executive role, keep it narrow and set a handover date.
13. No public funding and no disclosure rules: publish accounts and build small donors.
14. For the NNP: reunited, the opposition was three votes from winning the Town.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; all constituencies and polling divisions read 7 and 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 and 2026 general elections; National Democratic Congress; New National Party; Peter David); Caribbean National Weekly and Caribbean Today (DPM launch, Nov 2025); NOW Grenada (DPM executive and congress, Mar 2026); Caribbean Times / CMC (DPM congress, 22 Mar 2026); Wee FM (DPM congress and North America meetings); Mikey Live (DPM meeting and polling remarks, Oct 2026); OneNews St. Vincent (leaders' debate, Oct 2026); The New Today (DPM launch, Nov 2025; editorial on the NNP leadership); Caribbean National Weekly (NNP convention, Jun 2026); International IDEA Political Finance Database (Grenada); Nation News (OAS mission on campaign finance); The Rio Times (DPM slate, Oct 2026; results, 6 Nov 2026); Jamaica Gleaner / CMC (results, 6 Nov 2026). Shares, gaps and targets computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 18 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.